

Simultaneous Interpretations

Sometimes English grammar permits multiple interpretations and this appears to be intentional. Therefore, if we attempt to squeeze such passages into a single interpretation the result is an arbitrarily limited view of the full meaning.

The following is one such example where if we try to interpret the passage only one way, we end up with only a partial understanding of what is being said.

Psalm 37:23

The steps of a good man are ordered by the LORD: and he delighteth in his way.

Noun/pronoun breakdown	
Nouns	Pronouns
a good man	he
the LORD	his

Now, what's interesting about this example is that there is nothing structural in either the English or the Hebrew (1524 Bomberg Masoretic Text) that binds the pronouns "*he*" or "*his*" to either noun.

Thus, there are four possible permutations for resolving the pronouns to their antecedents and **they are all valid at the same time**:

he → a good man

his → he → a good man

Interpretation: the good man delights in his (LORD ordered) way

he → the LORD

his → he → the LORD

Interpretation: the LORD delights in His way

he → a good man

his → the LORD

Interpretation: the good man delights in the LORD's way

he → the LORD

his → a good man

Interpretation: the LORD delights in the (LORD ordered) good man's way

Discourse Anaphora vs. Syntactic Binding

At first glance, we might think that verse 24 restricts or limits which antecedent the pronouns in verse 23 can resolve to, but we would be mistaken.

Local syntactic binding only occurs inside a single clause. When a new clause or sentence begins, the pronoun does not necessarily resolve to the nearest appropriate pronoun/noun; it instead resolves to the active mental model for the most prominent topical noun phrase that fits the semantic conditions (in this case the verb *fall*).

Psalms 37:24

²³ The steps of **a good man** are ordered by the LORD: and he delighteth in his way.

²⁴ Though **he** fall, **he** shall not be utterly cast down: for **the LORD** upholdeth **him** with **his** hand.

What that means is that in verse 24 the pronouns “*he*”, “*he*”, and “*him*” all resolve directly to “*a good man*” and not to “*he*” or “*his*” (v23) like they would if these two verses were all one clause. The final “*his*” is syntactically bound to the local clause’s only noun: “*the LORD*”.

And so the interpretation for verse 23 remains and the interpretation for verse 24 could be read as:

Though a good man fall, a good man shall not be utterly cast down: for the LORD upholdeth a good man with His hand.

Dual-subject Pronominal Resolution

It can be surprising what the grammar reveals, as we have seen above. Here is another example:

Genesis 15:3-6

³ And Abram said, Behold, to me thou hast given no seed: and, lo, one born in my house is mine heir.

⁴ And, behold, the word of the LORD came unto him, saying, This shall not be thine heir; but he that shall come forth out of thine own bowels shall be thine heir.

⁵ And he brought him forth abroad, and said, Look now toward heaven, and tell the stars, if thou be able to number them: and he said unto him, So shall thy seed be.

⁶ And he believed in the LORD; and he counted it to him for righteousness.

It is plainly evident to us that verse 6 can be read as:

And Abram believed in the LORD; and the LORD counted it to Abram for righteousness.

But, what might not be plainly evident, is that the grammar permits another reading that is likely not well known. This is permitted by the fact that the pronouns “*he*” and “*him*” in the latter half of verse 6 are not syntactically restricted to either Abram or the LORD. Thus, the following reading is simultaneously valid:

And Abram believed in the LORD; and Abram counted it to the LORD for righteousness.